VICTORY 2026

English

Poem : 05

A Considerable Speck

Lecture – 05

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Topics *to be covered*

1. Overview
2. Line by line Explanation
3. Summary
4. Poetic Devices



Topic: Overview

Noticeable a tiny spot

Title: A Considerable Speck

Oxymoron (opposite/contradictory terms used)

Poet: Robert Frost

Published: 1936 (in the collection *"A Further Range"*)



The poem describes a moment when the speaker is writing at his desk. He notices a tiny mite (a small insect) on his page, which he initially thinks is just a speck of dust. However, upon closer inspection, he realizes it's alive and moving

It's a a wonderful graphic description of intelligence action.

tiny spot — under

A speck that would have been beneath my sight — Enj.

On any but a paper sheet so white

Ran Set off across what I had written there.

And I had idly poised my pen in air — stopped

To stop it with a period of ink — stop / dot — lazily, without any purpose

When something strange about it made me think, — All- 's'

This was no dust speck by my breathing blown, — " 'b'

But unmistakably a living mite — a tiny insect

feelings With inclinations it could call its own. — All - 'c'

Enjambment – Continuation

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. A speck that would have been _____ my sight.

A. beneath

B. within

C. under

D. beyond

Topic: A Considerable Speck

It paused as with suspicion of my pen,

And then came **racing** wildly on again

To where my **manuscript** was not yet dry;

Then **paused** again and either drank or smelt-

With **loathing**, for again it turned to fly.

Plainly with an intelligence I dealt.



Racing: running
Manuscript: piece of written text
Paused: stopped
Loathing: strong dislike or hatred
Plainly: clearly

Topic: A Considerable Speck

It seemed too tiny to have room for feet,

Yet must have had a set of them complete

To express how much it didn't want to die.

It ran with terror and with cunning crept.

It faltered: I could see it hesitate;

Then in the middle of the open sheet

Cower down in desperation to accept

Whatever I accorded it of fate.



Room: here, space
A set of them: here, a set of feet
Cunning: cleverness
Faltered: walked with less confidence
Hesitate: uncertain / reluctant
Cower down: hand down and move backward in fear
Desperation: a state of hopelessness which leads to extreme behaviour
Accorded: granted

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. The poet of this poem is:

A. William Wordsworth

B. William Shakespeare

C. Robert Williams

D. Robert Frost

Topic: A Considerable Speck

more loving/caring than you

I have none of the **tenderer-than-thou**

Group

Collectivistic regimenting love

strictly imposed by the law or society

With which the modern world is being **swept.**

↓ influenced

almost invisible

But this poor **microscopic item** now!

Philosophical thoughts

Since it was nothing I knew evil of

(Not an animal lover)

I let it lie there till I hope it slept.

He decided not to 'fiddle' with it.



tenderer-than-thou: more loving / delicate than you are (attitude)
Collectivistic: concerned with some group, class or society, not individuals
Regimenting: something imposed strictly by the state or society
Swept: strongly affected
Microscopic item: almost invisible insect (mite)

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. The mite crouched down:

A. at the edge of the paper

B. in the middle of the paper

C. near the speaker

D. under the paper

Topic: A Considerable Speck

ability to think

*I have a **mind** myself and recognize*

*Mind when I meet with it in any **guise***

happy form

No one can know how glad I am to find

*On any sheet the least **display of mind.***

smallest

intelligence



Mind: Ability to think
Guise: Cover
Display of Mind: show of intelligence

Topic: Poetic Device

1. **Rhyme scheme:** *irregular rhyme* has been used – Free verse

2. **Oxymoron:** the adjective used for a noun is contrary to the noun's qualities.
   'Considerable speck'
   opposite

3. **Imagery:** visual imagery has been deployed to show the mite's movement.

4. **Anaphora:** two or more consecutive lines start with the same word
   I let it lie there till I hope it slept.
   I have a mind myself and recognize

5. **Inversion:** the structure of the sentence is altered
   changed
   This was no dust speck by my breathing blown,
   Plainly with an intelligence I dealt.
   Yet must have had a set of them complete
   On any sheet the least display of mind



Topic: Poetic Device

6. **Alliteration:** repetition of a consonant sound at the start of two or more consecutive words.

Been beneath
Made me
Breathing blown
Something strange
Could call
My manuscript
Too tiny
Have had
Cunning crept
With which
Mind myself

Purpose of using alliteration → Rhythm

Consonance

Assonance

Topic: Summary

Read - Key words and Phrases

At first glance, the poem appears to be a mere description of a tiny mite, but soon we realise that the poet develops a strong comparison between an insignificant yet intelligent mite and the powerful yet mindless humans who live a dull life.

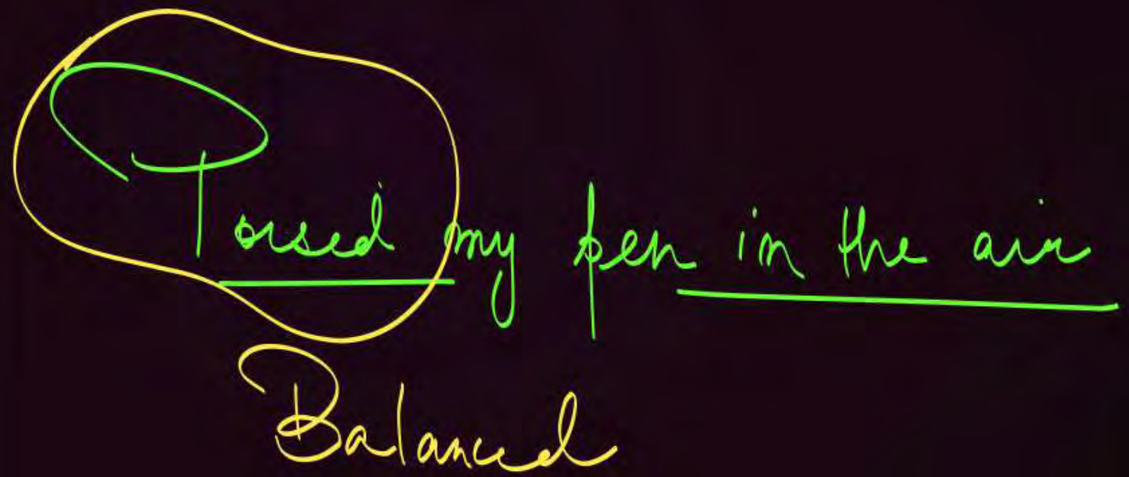
The narrator sees a living mite running on a white sheet of paper on which he was trying to write something. He takes a pause and waits for the mite to move away. The mite stops and smells the wet ink on the paper, tastes it hesitantly and finding it disfateful, runs away. The mite is scared for its life and thus seeks a safer place. The narrator is extremely impressed by its cunningness. He does not kill it, not because of any generosity or mercy but because he feels that the mite, though so tiny, still has a mind which it puts to use and saves itself from a difficult situation. He respects its brain and instinctive nature.

Topic: Summary

He believes that it should therefore be given a chance for survival. The narrator himself is a man with a mind and gives credibility and honor to those who have a mind of their own and use it effectively. Here, the poet has targeted those humans who are dull and inactive and refrain from using their faculities. He believes that a mite with intelligence is superior to a human who is witless and brainless. The poem is a satire on dullards. Frost thus, stresses that he judged people on the basis of their mental ability.

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. Find a word in the poem which means *'balanced'*:



A. period

B. poised

C. collectivistic

D. paused

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. The world *'inclinations'* here means:

Instinct
↓
inner feelings

(A) bending

(B) needs

(C) natural behaviour

feelings

(D) natural instinct

Topic: A Considerable Speck

#Q. Through the poem, Frost has displayed:

A. a struggle of survival of a tiny insect

B. the writer's feeling of pity for the mite.

C. a wonderful graphic description of intelligence action

D. a speck that looked like a mite


Thank You